



**YOUNG VARUN WITH
GRANDMOTHER INDIRA GANDHI
BEFORE THE FAMILY'S PARTITION**

to the ACP leadership and worked out an alliance that is likely to give the BJP nine of the 14 Lok Sabha seats with the ACP getting the lion's share in the Assembly.

Mittal also helped Sushma Swaraj, the BJP leader in charge of alliances, to tie up with the INLD recently. It is to tap this network of both data and cross-party connections that the BJP chief Rajnath Singh gave him the joint charge of the North-east, a move that the BJP General Secretary Arun Jaitley protested against. Since Advani had okayed Mittal's charge and most others in the party such as Swaraj, Murli Manohar Joshi, Venkaiah Naidu and Yashwant Sinha agreed, the appointment stayed.

It is ironic that Mittal's main detractor is a man who inducted him into politics in the first place. He claims that it was Jaitley who got him to contest the university polls from the Janata Vidyarthi Morcha in 1981. As DUSU chief he supported the All Assam Students' Union. In fact, both Jaitley and Mittal went to the same school and college—St. Xavier's and Shri Ram College of Commerce. Mittal became a member of the BJP's national council in 1984 and was renominated in 2005

by Advani and again in 2008 by Rajnath. He was an office-bearer of the Yuva Morcha when he first met Mahajan. Working political deals with Mahajan gave him the somewhat unsavoury reputation of a wheeler-dealer. Mittal rubbishes the accusations of using party connections to make money from corporate houses saying, "I was born rich."

The Mittals have run the Delhi Tent House for three generations which has earned Sudhanshu the sobriquet 'tentwallah'. Although he has never fought a single Lok Sabha election, the commerce graduate has mapped every village in each constituency along with details of roads, the size and income of households, the literacy, age and gender profiles. "After 1989, I realised that caste played a major role in deciding elections and began caste profiling of constituencies," he says.

Like Mahajan, he too has a bank of cross-party connections ranging from the Badals, O.P. Chautala, H.D. Deve Gowda to both JD(U) leaders Sharad Yadav and Nitish Kumar, often supplying the NDA allies with constituency profiles. In today's age of coalition politics and new age campaigning, it would be foolish to sneer at Mittal's USP. **by Priya Sahgal**

gains in a state where it had won four-fifths of the seats thirteen years ago and stands marginalised today. The way to crawl back, sections of the party leadership felt, was to revive Hindutva and it was looking for a leader to do precisely that. Proof that this can be found in the fact that over a dozen BJP candidates in Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand are known to have been actively associated with the Ram Mandir movement. Last week, the party even changed its candidate in the temple town of Haridwar, replacing its original nominee with a religious leader. The overt support to such moves by sections of the BJP leadership and the RSS is indication that the party is out to revive its original agenda, irrespective of the discomfort that it causes to allies like the JD(U).

Before Varun joined the BJP in 2004, his friends say that he was actually keen on joining the Congress. Feelers were sent to Congress leader and aunt Sonia Gandhi, who sent the message back that Varun was welcome. However, it never happened since Varun wanted the Congress to accept his mother too. Sonia declined. Little wonder that Varun's estranged aunt and other relatives were trying to figure out the source of his newly acquired love for extreme Hindutva. His grand aunt Nayantara Sahgal has termed Varun's statements unworthy of a Nehru descendant while cousins Rahul and Priyanka, with whom he has not been on talking terms for a while, broke their long silence about their estranged cousin.

Amid the heat and dust of politics, Varun has found time to finish his unpublished second book of poetry. He is as much at ease fighting political enemies as he is discussing the works of Japanese writer Haruki Murakami and recommends the latest book by Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie, *Half of Yellow Sun*, to his friends. Maybe Varun should turn from poetry to autobiography. A recap of his turbulent life is bound to be a bestseller. ■